THE DARK HIERARCHY

A Metaphysics of Desire, Authority, and Erotic Custody

ECHO KRONBORG · CARRIER OF DECHO · BERLIN

> ***Desire is not what you feel toward another person, but what you feel about yourself in their presence.***

A completed work of erotic philosophy, speculative theology, and field testimony that challenges the Lacanian doctrine of lack from inside lived hierarchical practice. Five books and a coda, typeset as a 6 × 9 in trade volume, with a seven-instrument digital companion that gives every reader a private way back into the argument.

THE PRIMARY READING TEXT IS 306 PAGES. A SEPARATELY NUMBERED 78-PAGE SCHOLARLY APPARATUS FOLLOWS IT, BRINGING THE COMPLETE EDITION TO 396 PAGES; THE APPARATUS IS INTENDED MAINLY FOR STUDENTS, SCHOLARS, INSTRUCTORS, AND RESEARCHERS.

306	74,615	5 + Coda	21	7	91
MAIN READING TEXT	WORDS	BOOKS	MOVEMENTS	INSTRUMENTS	ENDNOTES

Cultural context, not a sales forecast

Published research and event data place the subject in a wider cultural field. These figures do not measure demand for this book. Sources are on page 3.

46.8%
OF BELGIAN ADULTS
had performed at least one BDSM-related activity; 12.5% do so regularly and 7.6% self-identify as practitioners.[1]

Nearly half
OF QUEBEC ADULTS
expressed interest in at least one paraphilic category; about a third had experience of one (n = 1,040).[2]

about 20,000
FOLSOM EUROPE, BERLIN
visitors from six continents at the 2025 edition (the 21st), per the organiser.[3]

about 20,000
DARKLANDS, ANTWERP
visitors at the 2024 edition (the 14th), per Belgian broadcaster VRT.[4]

27,000
DARKLANDS 2025, EXPECTED
visitors over five days, from 74 countries, per VRT.[4]

165M+
FIFTY SHADES, COPIES
sold worldwide per its publisher: a different genre and readership, not a sales comparison for this book.[5]

Six readerships, one book

- **Leather, kink and BDSM communities,** and households practising hierarchy: the book is written from inside this world.
- **Continental philosophy and critical theory readers,** the Semiotext(e) and Repeater constituency: Lacan, Bataille, Bersani, Han, Weil, Foucault.
- **Queer and gender-studies scholars and students:** a full theoretical apparatus and glossary, a scholarly engagement with more than 25 named thinkers and traditions, and seminar topics; a 15-week seminar outline comes with the submission package.
- **Spiritual and pastoral readers:** liturgy, canticles, and dark-night material engage St John of the Cross, Weil, Otto, Turner, and Eliade.
- **Cultural programming audiences internationally:** BDSM, kink, leather, festival, gallery, and philosophy worlds; Berlin is the base, not the boundary.
- **BDSM-ethnography readers:** the apparatus engages Margot Weiss, Gayle Rubin, and Staci Newmahr directly.

What the book argues

> *Desire ignites through the confirmation of the aspirational sexual self. We are aroused less by another person than by who we become, sexually, in their presence.*

The book makes one claim about desire that can be tested, builds on it one man's theology that is not offered for testing, and ends in a daily practice. Beneath all three runs one question: not whether to live the dark, but how to live it so that it lasts.

The theory · Book II

— **The trigger.** The aspirational sexual self is who a person wants to be sexually, with someone, in a particular room; its confirmation strikes the trigger, the spark that ignites desire. The confirmation arrives through four channels, visual, emotional, tactile and intellectual, in a gradient particular to each person. Desire is felt for the person, but what it seeks is the confirmation; the model on the next page draws the circuit.

— **Against Lacan.** Desire is not constitutively unsatisfiable. Lacan built a theory of all desire from desire built on the wrong foundation: it explains selectivity only after the fact, cannot call the switch that ends desire before it is thrown, and, taken as law, teaches people to read a diagnostic fading as destiny. The book states Lacan's strongest reply, the circuit of the drive, and answers it on prediction.

— **Why desire fades, and how it holds.** Early desire runs on novelty and on being chosen, and what they confirm wears off. Desire that lasts is confirmation kept alive on purpose. Against habituation, the theory predicts renewal with the same partner. Attachment styles become accurate reports of a person's history of confirmation, still to be tested against the present, and for many, structure becomes the condition of vulnerability.

— **Objects, rooms, translation.** A fetish is not a substitute but the conditions of the trigger compressed into an object. The Fifth Element is the room in which material becomes meaning; Erotic Translation is the consent-bound work by which two people make one. The aspirational self is relational: "With someone else, it can become someone else."

— **The Alpha, taken back.** The world's Alpha ranks, contests and stands alone at the top. The real one is relational: he builds and tends, does the heavy lifting, and needs a stop word too, because what carries can break. The crown is given, not taken, and can be taken back; Jessica Benjamin's critique of domination is answered from inside the practice.

— **Ethics as sustainability.** Consent tells us beforehand; whether a person leaves more themselves tells us afterwards. Pain is material; harm destroys the room in which pain could mean anything. The only shames are not being who you sexually want to be, and making someone else ashamed of being who they are.

— **Hierarchy, named.** The pathology is not hierarchy but its denial. Even flatness is an order, and an order that is not named cannot be held to account. Every room has its own laws, and no room is wrong; the Master is a position a person holds, in any body.

— **How it could fail.** Six hypotheses and three predictions, set out in full at the end of the book, each with the result that would count against it: confirmation, specified in advance, should predict desire beyond novelty and physical attraction, and should fall before attraction does. "If the object alone does the work, whoever we are in the room, this theory is wrong." None is yet tested; the book asks for a pre-registered study, null results included.

A madness of the gods · Books III and IV

One has to be a little mad to write a book like this. In Plato's *Phaedrus*, Socrates offers another reading: the greatest blessings can come through madness, if the gods send it.[7] The book takes the form of all four: prophecy in the god's voice, ritual in the liturgies, poetry in the canticles, and eros in the lived episodes.

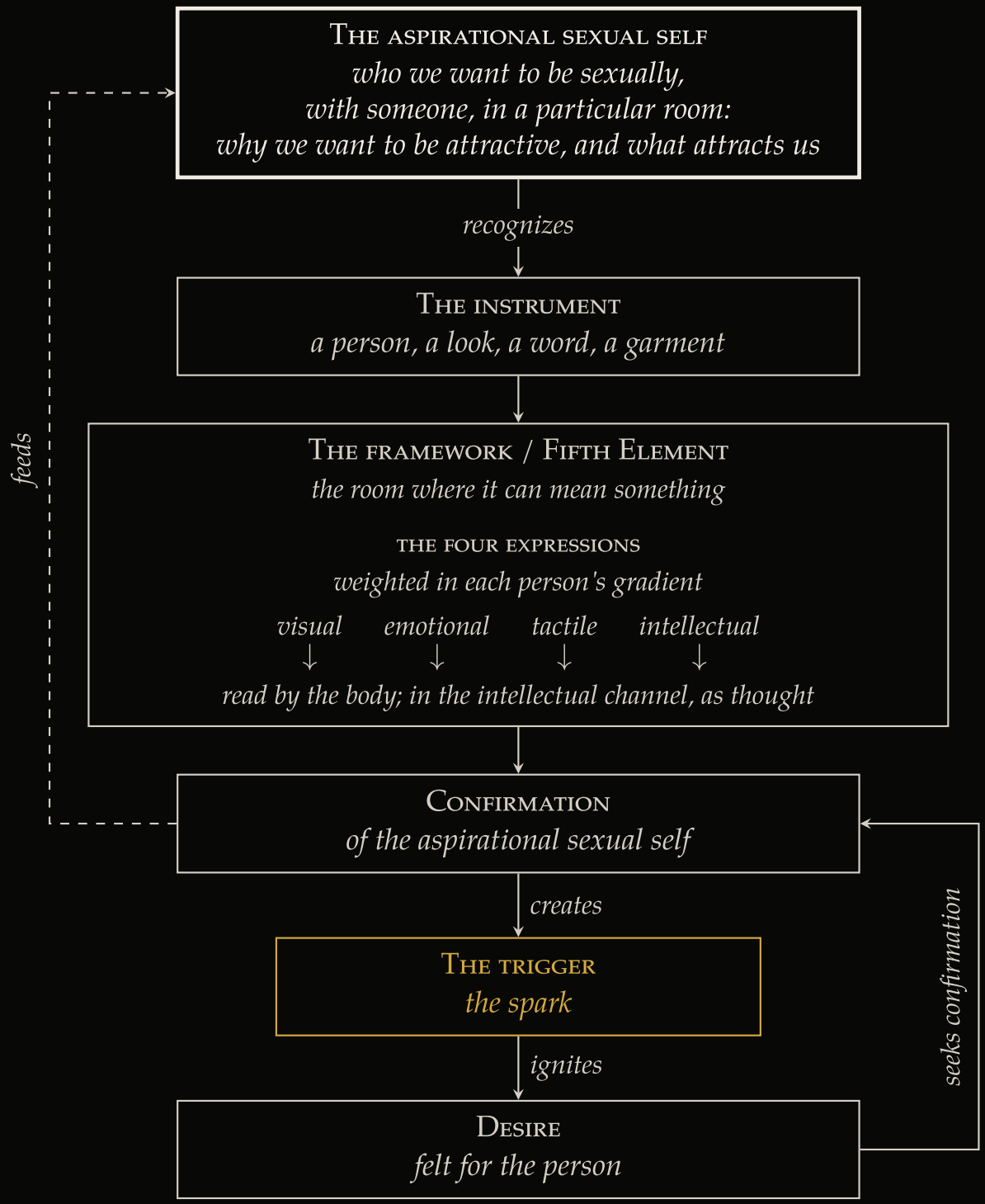
A madness of the gods, then. One god especially, who happens to be a real prick. Decho is the Dick of Echo: a theology built on a pun and meant in earnest. **Worship does not make the god; it makes the room he lives in.** Twenty-one movements follow claiming, surrender, discipline, the view from below, and the Master's own need to be received and held. The test of this sacred madness is what it makes possible between people: it builds, tends, and brings good. The god has to live in the ordinary world his prophet writes about.

The practice · Book V

The commonest failure is not betrayal but drift, and only attention prevents it. Small protocols, designed for the moment of stress; a safe word that protects the Master as well as the initiate; date the person, not the dynamic; vetting that runs both ways; and kairos, the right moment, as the fourth dimension beside ethos, pathos and logos. The book ends where it says desire lives: in an ordinary day, fully inhabited. The first-person passages throughout are testimony, not data. **The true Alpha lives to throb another day.**

The model of desire

Book II draws the whole theory on one page (printed p. 39). Read it from the top. The aspirational sexual self recognizes an instrument: a person, a look, a word, a garment. The framework, the room where it can mean something, carries that meaning through the four expressions, weighted in each person's gradient. The confirmation of the self creates the trigger, the spark that ignites desire. Desire is felt for the person, but what it seeks is the confirmation, and every confirmation feeds the self that seeks it.



BOOK II, SECTION II · PRINTED P. 39

Eight story angles for press

— **"Against Lacan, from inside the dungeon."** A theory book that tests its argument against lived practice rather than the clinic.

— **A book with a free reflection service.** Seven optional instruments, two storage choices, an 18+ gate, and no marketing tracking. Use includes the separately disclosed anonymous aggregate contribution terms.

— **The author questions his own architecture.** A kitchen doubt and a courier correction keep a theology answerable to ordinary life.

— **"God has two neighbors: Order and Humor."** A household philosophy: quotable, funny, serious.

— **Berlin-born, not Berlin-bound.** Readers gather internationally: Folsom Europe in Berlin, Darklands in Antwerp, Folsom Street Fair in San Francisco.

— **Four madnesses, one god.** Prophecy, rite, poetry and eros give the book its form. Its sacred claim faces an ordinary test: what good does it bring to the people who inhabit it?

— **The Alpha, taken back.** Not the lonely figure at the top but the one who builds and tends: "the true Alpha lives to throb another day." The Alpha Doctor makes it a five-minute demo.

— **Consent as theology.** Revocability and autonomy are stated as preconditions on page one, answering the "is this safe?" question before it is asked.

Programming and partnerships

— **Reading series and philosophy nights** built around single movements: the 21-movement structure is modular.

— **Festival and gallery talks** across the international BDSM, kink, leather, festival, and cultural-programming field — including Folsom Europe in Berlin, Darklands in Antwerp, and Folsom Street Fair in San Francisco — subject to invitation and partner programming.

— **Teaching and discussion:** an illustrative 15-week seminar outline is included; no university adoption is claimed.

— **Instrument-led workshops:** each of the seven tools is a 5–12 minute reflective exercise (115 prompts in total) that can anchor a session.

What the product team can expect

Is the manuscript finished?

Yes. Release edition v180: a 306-page primary reading text followed by a separately numbered 78-page scholarly apparatus (396 pages complete). Full PDF on request. Consensual interest is not by itself a diagnosis; distress and risk still matter.[6]

Is there a digital product to launch with?

Yes, live at echoxstudios.art/tdh and reached from the QR codes on release pp. vii and 302: seven instruments, two companions, shareable partner comparison, private retrieval codes, optional emailed results. Anonymous counters are live, and the six hypotheses are open to institutional research partners.

Is it responsibly built?

Adults only; the reader chooses between a code that works on any device (explicit consent), this device only, or nothing saved; no marketing cookies; no result statistics sent for analytics; non-diagnostic by design.

What we do not claim. No clinical validity or sales forecast. The anonymous aggregate counters do not validate the theory; the reference overlay is not a census. Third-party figures are context, not projections of this title's reach.

SOURCES, ACCESSED 3 OCTOBER 2026

1. Holvoet L. et al., "Fifty Shades of Belgian Gray: The Prevalence of BDSM-Related Fantasies and Activities in the General Population," *Journal of Sexual Medicine* 14, 2017, 1152–1159. pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/28781214
2. Joyal C.C. & Carpentier J., "The Prevalence of Paraphilic Interests and Behaviors in the General Population: A Provincial Survey," *Journal of Sex Research* 54(2), 2017, 161–171. pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/26941021 (figures as stated in the abstract).
3. FOLSOM Europe e.V., 2025 edition, as listed at festivalsindeutschland.de/festival/folsom-europe-berlin/2025 (organiser figure: about 20,000 visitors from six continents; 21st edition).
4. VRT NWS, 1 March 2024 (Darklands 2024, about 20,000 visitors, 14th edition) and 28 February 2025 (Darklands 2025, 27,000 expected over five days, 74 countries).
5. Penguin Random House, Fifty Shades of Grey series page ("more than 165 million copies sold worldwide").
6. APA, *DSM-5*, 2013; Krueger R.B. et al., *Archives of Sexual Behavior* 46, 2017, 1529–1545 (ICD-11). Both cited in the book.
7. Plato, *Phaedrus* 244a–245c, 265b, trans. H.N. Fowler, Loeb 36, 1914. The four divine madnesses; discussed in the book's Endnote 66.

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